

■ By Priya Sahgal

On July 11, a special Indian Air Force aircraft with a joint director of the Intelligence Bureau took off from Delhi for Srinagar. Its purpose was to ferry an important passenger back to the national capital. As National Conference chief Omar Abdullah wrote in his blog, "It was not a dreaded terrorist or a separatist leader but PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti". Even though the PDP has only one MP, Mufti was flown to Delhi to attend a UPA meeting.

With the critical vote of confidence less than a week away, it is open season in Delhi as every single Lok Sabha member is being wooed for that crucial vote. Where the network is weak, allies are being flown in to the capital for talks. After all, everyone remembers 1999 when the Atal Bihari Vajpayee Government fell by just one vote. So, as soon as Union Commerce Minister Kamal Nath saw Dayanidhi Maran on television saying that he may abstain during the vote of confidence in Parliament, he immediately dialled Chennai. At the end of the conversation, Maran agreed that he could be "persuaded" to change his mind—if the Congress president and the prime minister asked him to.

Suddenly everyone has morphed into an Amar Singh avatar, bargaining fast and furious for that one deciding vote. Small regional parties that were ignored earlier are now being wooed by no one less than the usually reticent Sonia



Hope and DESPAIR

It's open season as the Congress looks for the magic number to win the confidence motion, wooing small regional outfits who are driving a hard bargain

Gandhi herself. If it is Amar Singh one day, it is Raj Babbar the next. Not just that, Sonia also dialled JMM chief Shibu Soren. Before the trust vote debate kicks off, she is expected to speak with over 300 MPs.

The regional chieftains, though, are taking their time to commit. After all, this is their 15 minutes of fame. Soren, silent all this while, has unrolled a lament list including how he was denied a Cabinet berth during the last reshuffle. He can afford the sulk. With five MPs, he is critical to the UPA's survival. The bait he will bite is apparently the coal portfolio but has added an

MOS slot to the list of demands for effect. Bytes are nuanced too. "The JMM knows its responsibility to bail out the Government," says Hemlal Murmu, party general secretary. "However, we would prefer if the Congress addresses a few of our grievances," he says. The NDA has also reached out, offering Soren the chief ministership to Jharkhand in exchange for his vote against the deal. Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar was asked by L.K. Advani to negotiate this.

Even the UPA allies have been roped in for crisis management. Sharad Pawar initiated talks with the Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS). Although Pawar has known TRS chief K. Chandrashekar Rao since his Youth Congress days, the connection did not take him very far. Even though one of his three MPs has turned rebel, Rao knows his market value. Once again